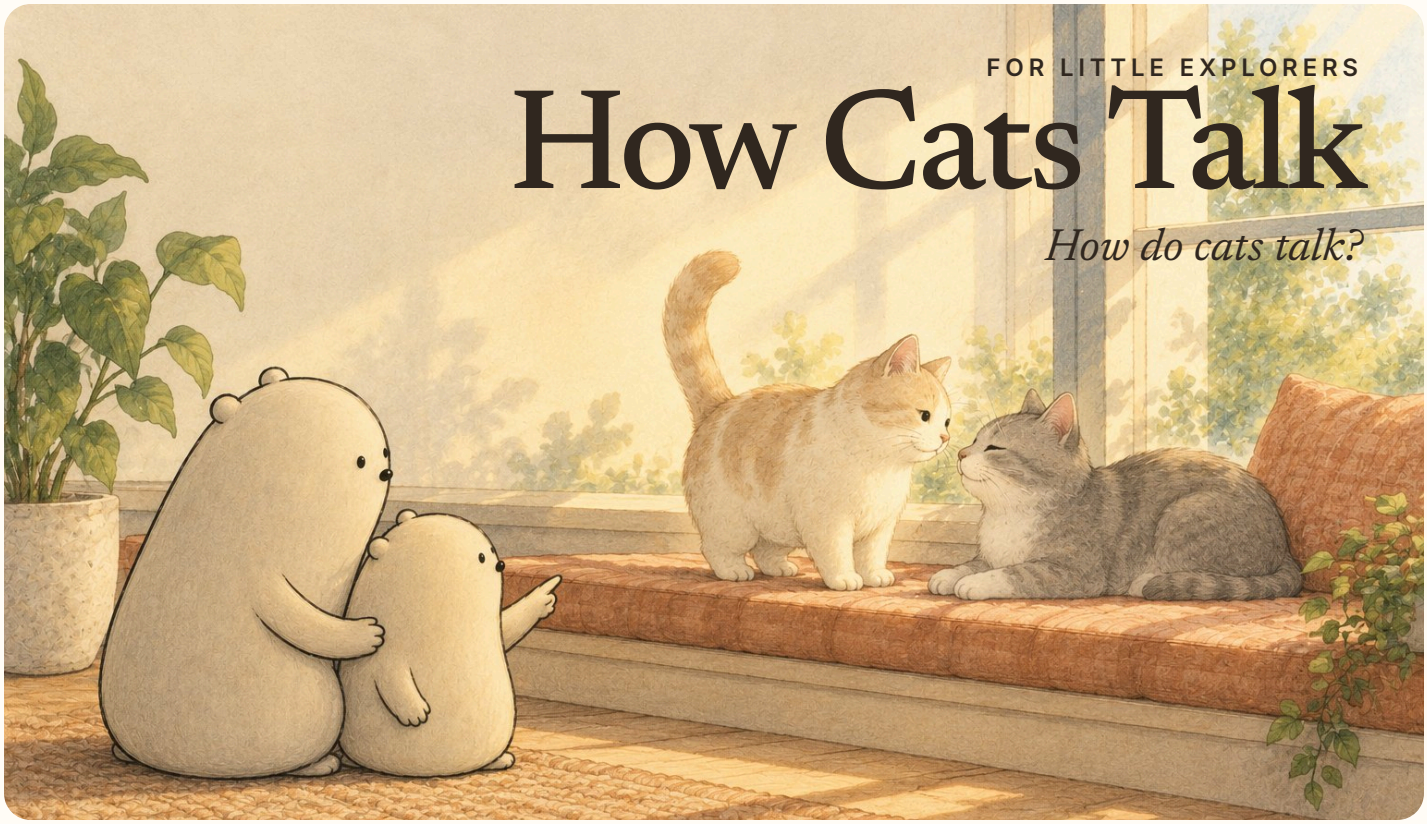


FOR LITTLE EXPLORERS

How Cats Talk

How do cats talk?

READ ALOUD

Mrrp! Meow! (Make two gentle cat sounds.) *Big Wonderer and Little Wonderer watch two cats meet in a sunny window. One cat walks closer with its tail held high.*

Cats talk with sounds and with their bodies. A meow may ask for food, company, or an open door. A quick mrrp can be a friendly hello.

ASK **Can you point to the cat saying hello with its tail?**

A purr often comes when a cat feels cozy, but a worried cat may purr too. We look at the whole cat for clues.

One cat turns its ears sideways. **Not now, please.** *Cats may hiss when they need more space. We stay back and let the cat choose.* (Hold up a quiet stop hand.)

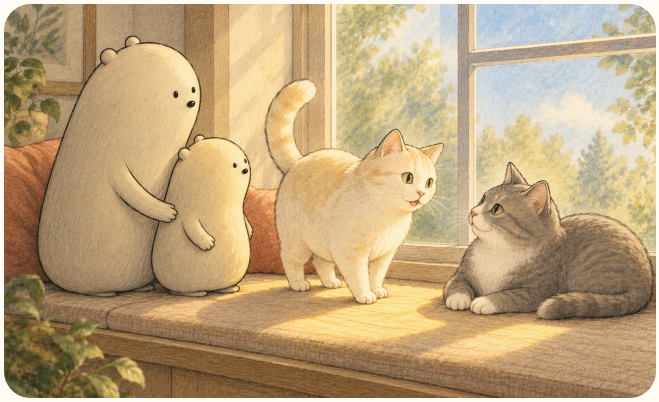
ASK **Can you make your arm into a high hello tail?**

The cats rest on a pillow and slowly close their eyes. A slow blink can say, "I trust you." Then one rubs its cheek on a chair leg, leaving a familiar scent.

ASK **What cat message would you like to copy?** *Big Wonderer and Little Wonderer slow-blink from a calm distance. Cats talk with sounds, tails, ears, eyes, and smells.*

Inside: a cat-talk story · sounds, tails, eyes, and smells · first-then-last · spot the difference · a scent-trail maze · counting to 20 · shapes and colors · rhymes and letter sounds · tracing and snipping · a coloring page · and a fold-up picture book.

Two cats say hello



Mrrp! Two cats meet

Two cats meet in a sunny window. One gives a quick mrrp. Cats can use meows, mrrps, purrs, and hisses to share different messages.

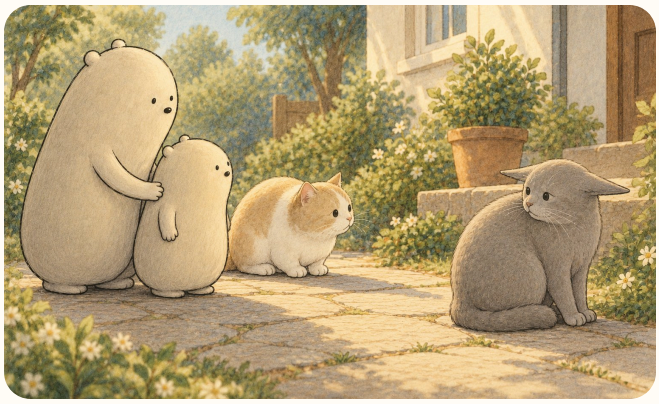
ASK Point to the cat making a friendly sound.



Tail up means hi

One cat walks closer with its tail held high. A relaxed, upright tail can be a friendly cat hello.

ASK Use your arm as a tail. Can you lift it into a gentle hello?



Ears say not now

The other cat turns its ears sideways and leans away. Its body is asking for more space. The friendly cat pauses.

ASK Point to the sideways ears. What should the other cat do?

TRY IT WITH A GROWN-UP First, sit with your grown-up near a familiar calm cat or a stuffed animal. Then, give one slow blink from a quiet distance. Never approach or touch an unfamiliar cat.

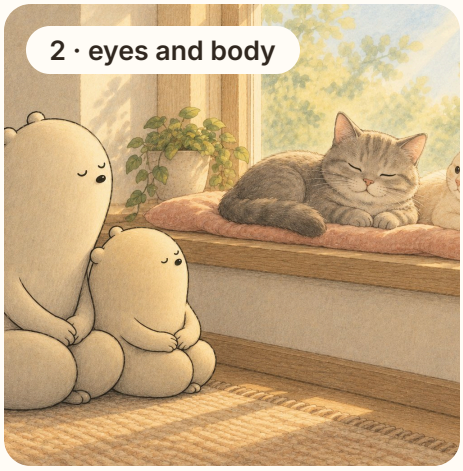
What do cat messages mean?

Cats combine sounds, body shapes, and smells. One clue cannot tell the whole story, so we look at the cat's ears, eyes, tail, and movement together.



Meow, mrrp, purr, hiss

A meow may ask for something. A mrrp can greet. Purring often happens during cozy moments, though worried cats can purr too. A hiss asks for space.



A slow, soft blink

A relaxed cat may slowly close and open its eyes. This gentle slow blink can show trust. Sideways or flattened ears can mean not now.



Rub, rub, familiar place

A cat has scent glands around its cheeks. Rubbing a cheek on a chair leg leaves a scent message that helps the place smell familiar.



Look at the whole cat

A tail, ears, eyes, sound, and movement work together. A friendly cat may hold its tail up, look soft and relaxed, and offer a mrrp or slow blink.

ASK Point to a sound clue and a body clue.

(If a cat turns away, crouches, flattens its ears, or hisses, give it plenty of space.)

Every cat is different. *One cat may meow often. Another may be quiet. Messages can change with the place and moment, so a grown-up watches the whole cat with you.*

EXPERIMENT WITH A GROWN-UP First, choose a familiar calm cat or a stuffed animal with your grown-up. Then, watch its ears, eyes, and pretend tail without touching. Last, copy one gentle message together, such as a slow blink or an arm held like a hello tail.

Which message goes with which clue?

Three cat clues: a high tail, sideways ears, and a slow blink. Each has a matching message.

1 Use your finger to join each cat clue to the message it can share.



a high, relaxed tail



sideways ears



a slow blink



not now



I trust you



hello

WHY? Cat clues work together. Look at the whole cat and let the cat choose whether to come closer.

2 Shapes and colors in the sunny window

Point to each shape, then say its color with your grown-up.



yellow circle

The warm sun spot looks like a circle.



pink triangle

A cat ear looks like a triangle.



blue square

A windowpane looks like a square.



green oval

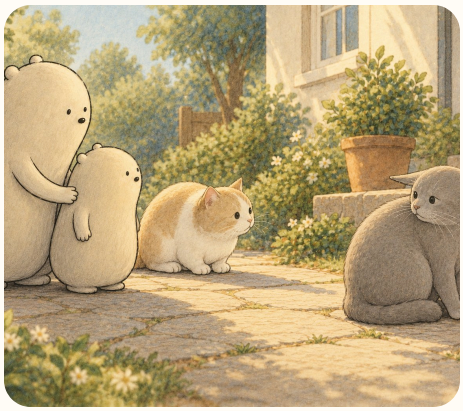
A cat eye can look like an oval.

ASK Can you find something square in your room?

What happened first?

Grown-up: point to each picture and tell it in a few words. Tell the story together using First, Then, and Last. Little explorer circles 1, 2 or 3 under each picture.

1 A careful cat hello



1 2 3



1 2 3



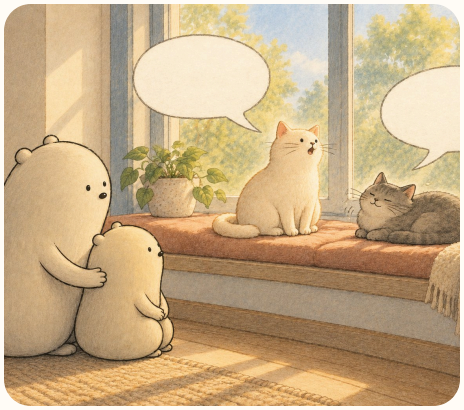
1 2 3

First, two cats meet. Then, one lifts its tail. Last, sideways ears ask for space.

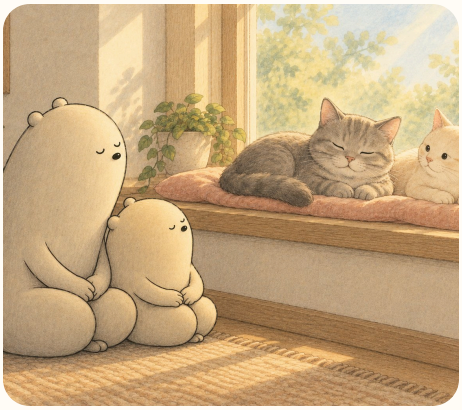
2 A quiet message



1 2 3



1 2 3



1 2 3

First, the cat mrrps. Then, it slow-blinks. Last, it rubs the chair.

TALK ABOUT IT What might the cats say with their bodies next?

Spot 5 differences

The two window pictures look the same, but 5 things changed. Point to each one, then circle it in the bottom picture. Color a dot for each one you find.

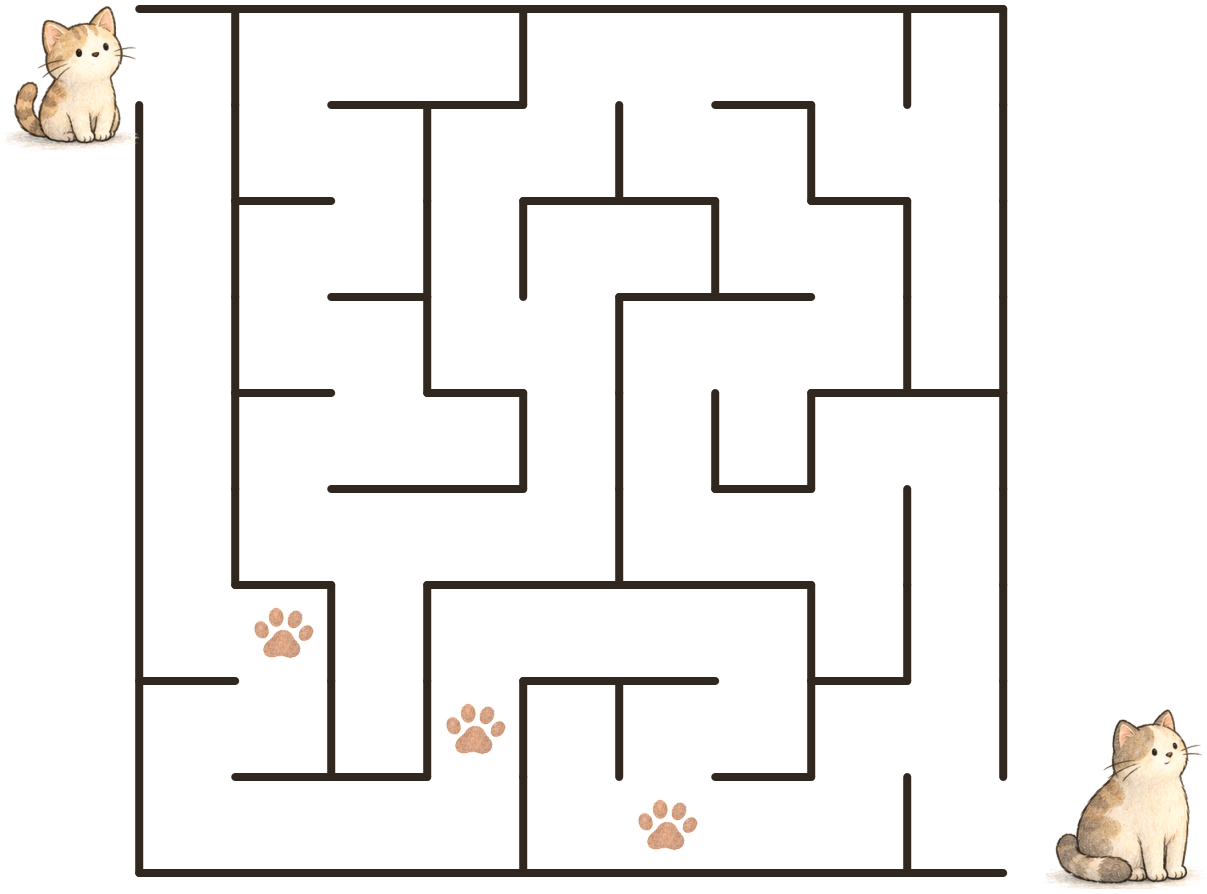


I found: ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

Follow the scent trail

A kitten is following a smelly paw-print trail to its cat friend. Help the kitten find the way and touch the three paw prints along the path.

First, trace the way with a finger.
Then, touch each paw print as you pass it.
Last, follow the way again with your finger.

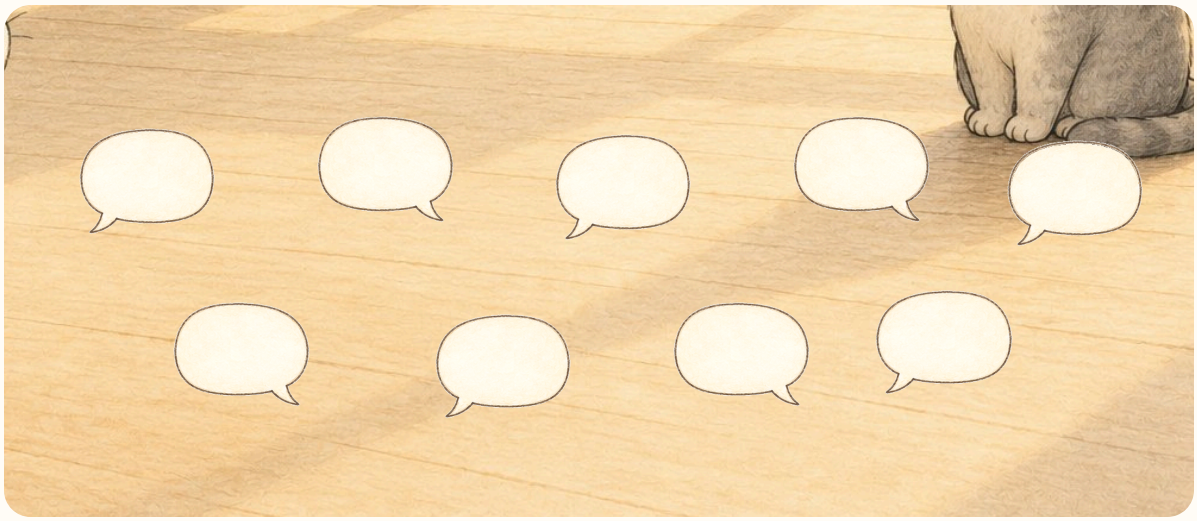


Paw prints spotted:

WHY DO CATS SNIFF? Smells carry information. Cats sniff places, objects, and other cats to notice familiar scents and learn what has been nearby.

Cat-message count

1 Count the meow speech bubbles. Circle how many.

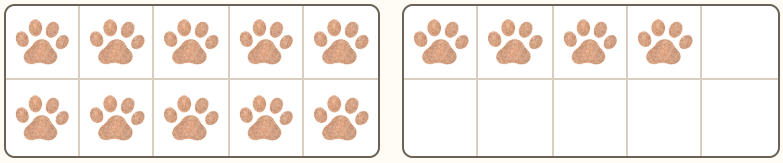


Touch each meow speech bubble once as you count. Put a crayon dot on each bubble you touch.

8 9 10 12

2 Count the paw prints. Circle the number.

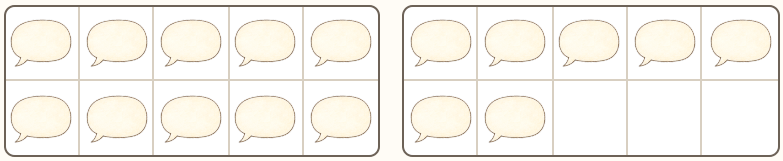
One full frame is 10. Then count on: 11, 12…



13 14 16

3 Count the meow speech bubbles. Circle the number.

10 and some more.

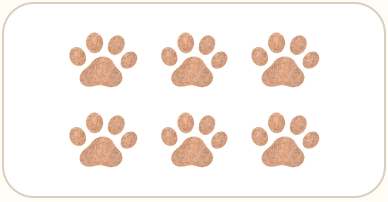


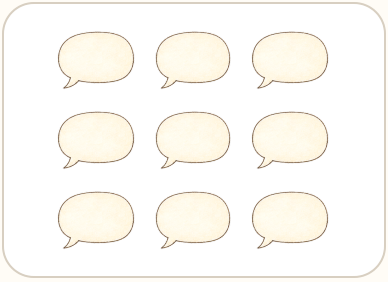
15 17 20

4 Find the number 12. Circle it.

7 12 15 20 10

5 Point to the group with MORE.





Cat picture stories

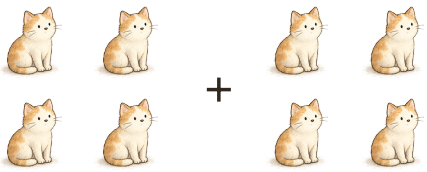
A stretch, just for fun. Grown-up reads each little story. Count the first group, then count on with the second group. Little explorer circles the answer.

2 cats sit by the window. 3 more cats sit nearby. How many cats?



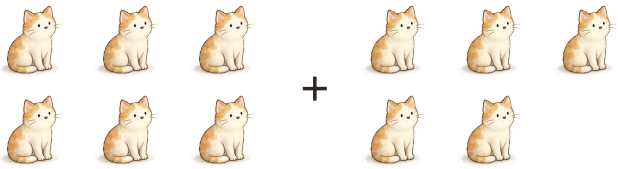
2 + 3 = (4) (5) (6)

4 cats cross the sun spot. 4 more cats cross the cushion. How many cats?



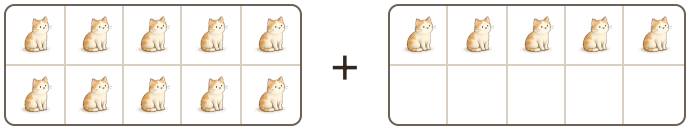
4 + 4 = (7) (8) (9)

6 cats sit near the window. Then 5 more cats join them. How many cats?



6 + 5 = (10) (11) (13)

10 cat pictures fill the frame. 5 more cat pictures join them. How many cats?



10 + 5 = (14) (15) (16)

Sounds in the sunny window

C c

This is the letter C, c. It says /k/, like the start of cat. Point to each C, c together.

1 Which pictures start with /c/, like *cat*? Circle them.


cat


can


cup


sun


bee


mug

2 Rhyme time! Grown-up says the three words. Point to the two that rhyme.


cat


hat


sun


tail


snail


bee


mug


bug


log

3 Read it together. Point to each word as you say it.


The **cat** can purr in the **sun**.



The **bug** sits by the **mug**.


4 Just for fun: touch each letter, then say the word fast.


c a t


c a n

Trace and snip

Count the pictures together. Trace the first number with a finger, then trace the dotted numbers with a crayon. Start at the dot.



1 1 1 1



2 2 2 2



3 3 3 3



4 4 4 4



5 5 5 5

Snip along the scent trail

With a grown-up helping, snip along the wavy line from the kitten to its friend. Safety scissors, and a grown-up holds the paper. Keep every printed picture on the page; do not cut out loose pieces.





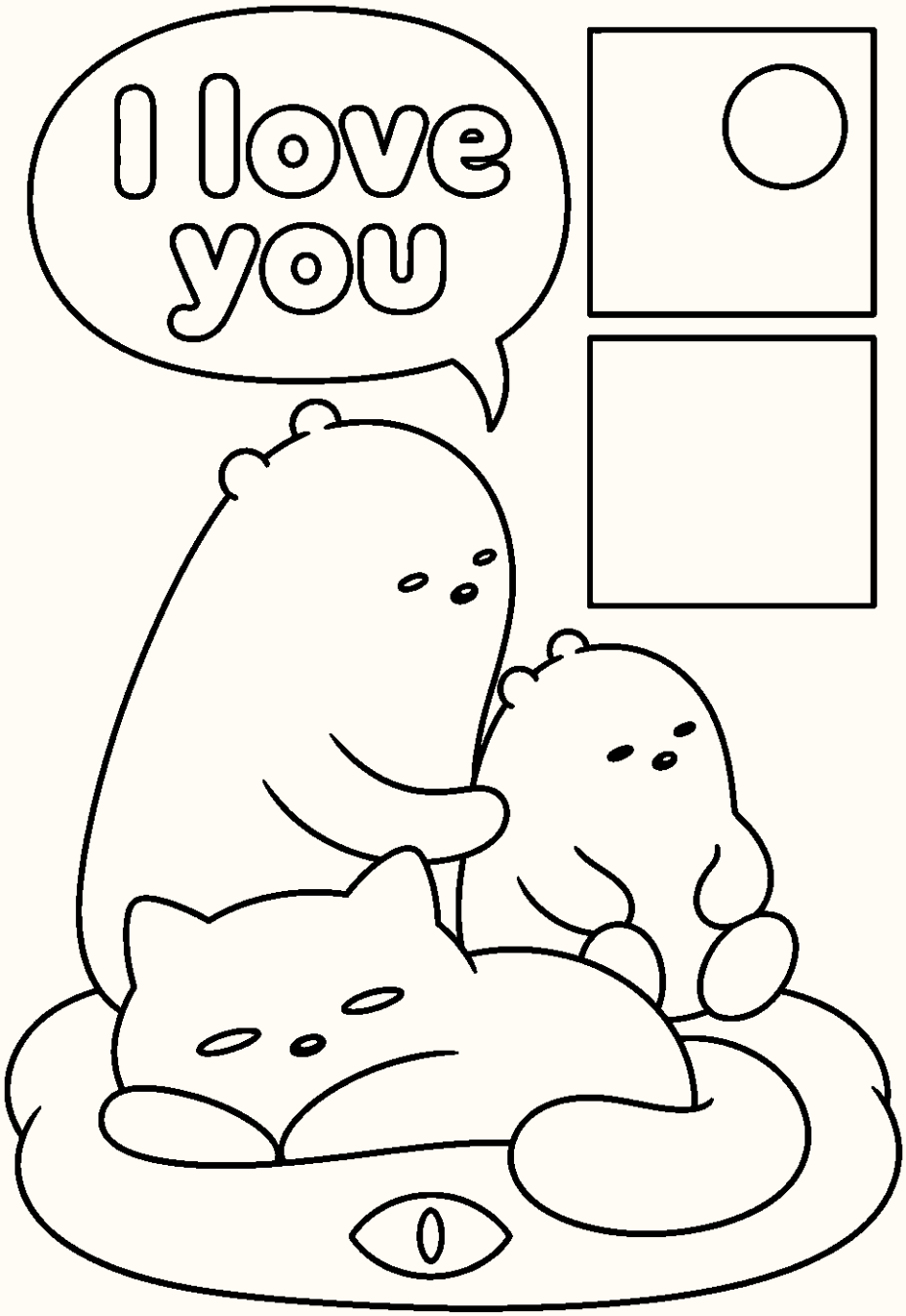
Color the slow-blinking cat

First, color the big slow-blinking cat.

Then, color the pillow and window shapes any colors you like.

Last, circle the speech bubble that says “I love you”.

Try to stay inside the lines. Big and Little Wonderer can be any color you like.

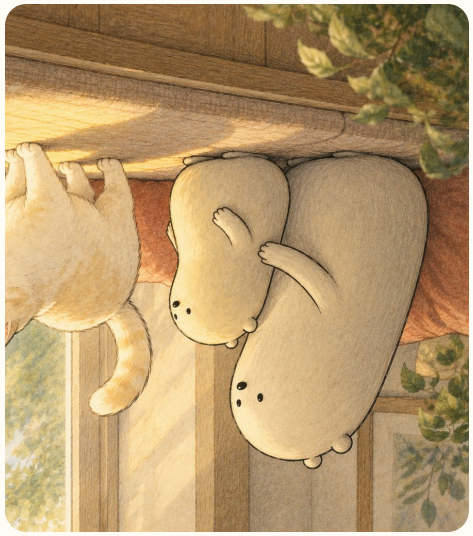


How Cats Talk

FOR LITTLE EXPLORERS



How do cats talk?



Two cats meet. Mrrp! says one.



A tail held high can say hello.



Sideways ears say, “Not now, please.”



A gentle meow can ask for something.



Sounds, bodies, and smells share cat messages.



Cheek rubs leave a familiar scent.



Slow blinks can say, “I trust you.”

How to fold the picture book

1. Print the picture sheet on one page, landscape, at 100% (no scaling).
2. Fold it in half the long way, then open it. Fold it in half the short way, then in half again; open it flat.
3. **Grown-up only:** fold it in half the short way and cut along the middle fold from the folded edge to the center crease.
4. Open it, fold it the long way again, and push the ends together so the slit opens into a little book. Page 1 goes on the front.

Read it together: one picture, a few words on each page. Ask "what do you see?" before you turn the page.